Science Fiction at Its Peak

I was very proud of the stories I was writing now. It seemed to me that they were much more deftly written than my stories of the 1940s. I think so to this day.

It seems to me that most people associate me with the 1940s and think of the positronic robot stories, the Foundation series, and, of course, "Nightfall," as the stories of my peak period. I think they're all wrong. I think my peak period came later—in 1953 and the years im-diately following.

By now, after all, the pulpishness in my writing had completely disappeared. That had been taking place all along, through the 1940s, but between what Walter Bradbury taught me and what I had learned at Breadloaf, the change accelerated under my own deliberate prodding.

My writing became ever more direct and spare, and I think it was The Caves of Steel that lifted me a notch higher in my own estimation. I used it as a model for myself thereafter, and it was to be decades before I surpassed that book in my own eyes.

Yet even as The Caves of Steel was raising my science fiction to a new level of expertise, something new was beginning.

A certain publisher, Henry Schuman, was interested in putting out a line of science books for teen-agers. For this purpose, he visited Bill Boyd in order to induce him to produce a teen-age version of his book Genetics and the Races of Man.

Bill felt entirely too busy at the moment to oblige, but once again he turned a nonfiction editor in my direction, as two years before he had done in the case of Angus Cameron of Little, Brown.

On the evening of April 14, 1953, therefore, I visited the Boyds in order to meet Schuman and talk to him.

I was perhaps not as eager to do nonfiction as I had been. After initial interest, Little, Brown had turned down The Puzzle of Life, and after initial interest, Macmillan had turned down The Chemistry of Life. What's more, it was clear by now that the textbook Biochemistry

and Human Metabolism was neither a critical nor a financial success. The second edition would be a clear improvement scientifically, but I had no